The Pacific Review

ISSN: 0951-2748 (Print) 1470-1332 (Online) Journal homepage: www.tandfonline.com/journals/rpre20

Thirty years of ASEAN: Achievements and challenges

Jörn Dosch & Manfred Mols

To cite this article: Jörn Dosch & Manfred Mols (1998) Thirty years of ASEAN: Achievements and challenges, The Pacific Review, 11:2, 167-182, DOI: 10.1080/09512749808719251

To link to this article: https://doi.org/10.1080/09512749808719251

Published online: 03 Apr 2007.

Submit your article to this journal

Article views: 1392

View related articles

Full Terms & Conditions of access and use can be found at
https://www.tandfonline.com/action/journalInformation?journalCode=rpre20

The Pacific Review, Vol. 11 No. 2 1998: 167–182

Thirty years of ASEAN: achievements and challenges

Jörn Dosch and Manfred Mols

Abstract This article first takes stock of the experiences, successes and shortcomings of Southeast Asian regionalism. During its thirty years, ASEAN has demonstrated the capability to react to international developments and to handle interstate relations on a constructive and cooperative basis. It is perhaps the most valuable achievement of ASEAN that the Association taking advantage of its well-established dialogue mechanisms has successfully managed to keep residual conflicts between the members (especially territorial dispute) from developing into full-blown crises. The article then deals with the question to what degree past experiences, performances, patterns of organization and past interpretations of ASEAN's role in the international system should be maintained and where innovation is required. We argue that although ASEAN should not surrender its basic rules and norms, the Association requires re-engineering in key sectors to meet the challenges of the new international order in the aftermath of the Cold War.

Keywords ASEAN; international relations; regional security cooperation; economic integration.

The changing international context of ASEAN

In the early 1990s, we witnessed an endless debate about the emergence of a 'new world order'. Even without President Bush's magic and vague words, an international discussion about the basic structure of the post-Cold War world was necessary and inevitable (see Mols 1993 for details). At the beginning of the decade a sort of end-of-history spirit proved to be prevalent, with Fukuyama's position as a shibboleth among the Western

Jörn Dosch is Assistant Professor of Political Science and Deputy Director of the Asia-Pacific Research Programme at the University of Mainz, Germany. He specializes in politics in Southeast Asia, US foreign policy, and international relations theory.

Manfred Mols is Professor of Political Science and Head of the Department of Area Studies at the University of Mainz. His research interests include regional integration in Latin America and Asia, democracy in Latin America and cooperation in the Pacific Rim.

Address: Institute of Political Science, Johannes Gutenberg-University Mainz, Colonel-Kleinmann-Weg 2, 55099 Mainz, Germany. E-mail: jdosch@mail.uni-mainz.de

© Routledge 1998 0951–2748

powers and probably elsewhere (see Jensen 1990 for Fukuyama's 1989 article and comments). It was not the idea as such that was attractive, but a widespread feeling of relief because a cluster of totalitarian and authoritarian states and their claim of a world revolution seemed to be fading away. The huge Soviet Empire simply dissolved, and this offered hope that a new and lasting peace, based on people's consent, would prosper – world-wide on the basis of a consensual political order, shared values, free markets and large economic networks.

The story and its details have been reported again and again and need not be repeated with the circumspection of an historian. But the optimism was unfulfilled. Disintegration in the former Soviet Union and Yugoslavia; simmering unrest in parts of the Mediterranean, the Middle East, parts of South, Southeast and East Asia; the dangerous curtain of international silence regarding sub-Saharan Africa; and the unrestricted viability of religious–ideological movements such as Islamic fundamentalism illustrated – a new potential of chaos not foreseen in the dreams of a new world order. It was absolutely evident that the United States would remain for quite a time the only multi-dimensional superpower. Japan, with its long-lasting economic and technological success story, cautiously occupied a more prominent place on the international stage. Maastricht EU-Europe appeared, and in its wake NAFTA, MERCOSUR and a more prominent APEC (following the Seattle Summit of 1993). India became aware of a larger international environment. And China's economic pre-eminence at least for the next century loomed large on the horizon.

These elements do not necessarily add to the chaos potential, but rather it is vital to identify poles or centres of international tranquillity, stability and predictability. Exactly here ASEAN comes in. 'Enter ASEAN' in this context should not be understood as the appearance of a new player on the international stage that comes into its existence as unexpected as some of the dramaturgic figures in a Shakespearean play. ASEAN is a well-known participant assuming its role in a given act and in a given scene as part of a thoroughly conceived stage play.

The stage is the current international situation with its structures and norms. A reliable participant is an indispensable figure in the play who contributes significantly to its inner logic and coherence. Specifically ASEAN has been developing into a weighty and influential player within the international system. The association has achieved the reputation of a constructive and often far-sighted element of international order – particularly in Southeast and East Asia and its geopolitical environments. ASEAN is a proven figure and a proven actor. That substantial part of ASEAN's performance is the core motive of reflecting upon a political grouping which is able to look back on three decades of its existence and experiences. The other motive is the analytic curiosity of social science professionals who spent parts of their lives in studying what happened within a regional organization designed by its founding fathers

neither as an alliance nor with the objective of what political scientists and economists would call integration. Is ASEAN, therefore, a construct of cooperation and coordination *sui generis*? What is the secret of its success? And if the term success can be justified, what is, in terms of substantial indicators or arguments, the basis of ASEAN's success? And have there been failures or shortcomings? Finally, would it make sense to extrapolate past structures, past experiences and past ways of behaviour to a future international system in search of a renewed and restructured stable arrangement? To reflect upon thirty years of ASEAN is meaningless if we do not take a drastically altered international environment into consideration. This does not imply, however, that ASEAN's development and experiences before 1990 have become irrelevant. The contrary is true! But it also would be naive to assume that the Association can simply continue its successful performance carried out during the past decades. ASEAN is a living organism, implying flexibility, adaptation and innovation. To study ASEAN's past falls short if not immediately connected to future prospects and perspectives and vice versa. Sir Winston Churchill was right by saying our capability to foresee the future exactly equals our capability to grasp the past.

ASEAN's past experiences: the secret of its success story

ASEAN did not come into existence out of a long-standing geopolitical cohesiveness and common history. There had been many years of experiment and visions which started with pan-Asian conferences in Delhi, the famous Bandung Conference of 1955, and first endeavours of Southeast Asian regionalism called MAPHILINDO and Association of Southeast Asia (ASA) (Mols 1996: Ch. 2.3). That five states came together and declared more or less openly a future unity between themselves and other states in the region had no historic precedent and perhaps only a relatively impermeable politico-geographical argument: the firm desire to remain minimally affected by the new colonizing styles of the principal actors within the framework of East–West tension. ASEAN was born when the region's political leaders had strong reasons to believe that their countries could become prominently involved in the global game of East–West confrontation. The United States had just revived President Eisenhower's 'Domino Theory' of 1954, making Southeast Asia aware of communism's aggressive expansionism and the US decision to comprehensively contain it. The states which recently had achieved independence from colonialism wanted to avoid new dependence or the emergence of repeated great power rivalry in the region. Independence as far as possible, autonomy as far as realizable, the chance to define its own development and economic progress, welfare and stability, and a common strategy to achieve these goals in an equilibrated way were the common denominators which led to the Bangkok Declaration of 1967,

ASEAN's founding document. It has to be considered a most remarkable achievement that ASEAN was born despite regional conflicts, particularly of a territorial nature. Quite a few of the future ASEAN states, for example, lived on the verge of open armed conflicts with each other, especially the period of confrontation (*Konfrontasi*) between Sukarno's Indonesia and Malaysia, 1963–65 (Jorgensen-Dahl 1982; Anwar 1994: 23–32).

Our unforgotten colleague and friend Kernial S. Sandhu defined the promotion of stability and security as the primary goal of ASEAN (Sandhu 1992: xiv) and was achieved internally (mutual relations among the member countries) and externally (*vis-à-vis* ASEAN's international environment). Both goals were accomplished through a very simple and at the same time very complicated mechanisms: dialogue at six levels:

- There exists a continuous process of coordination and adjustment in many fields of mutual political interest including economic tuning. The current 300-plus summits, ministerial meetings and committee discussions contribute to a tight network of dialogue procedures which engender and even guarantee not only remarkable degrees of problem and conflict solving, but also mutual trust, mutual closeness and a number of concrete cooperative undertakings.
- Interstate and/or intergovernmental conflict and territorial disputes still endure and will possibly remain for quite a while, because 'the region has always contained within itself various seeds of potential conflicts, both domestic and regional or inter-state' (Djiwandono 1996: 341). Apart from the multilateral South China Sea conflict in which extra-regional states like China and Taiwan are involved, seventeen exclusive interstate conflicts within ASEAN-7 can be identified. Malaysia is involved in thirteen of these disputes, followed by Vietnam (six), the Philippines (four), Thailand and Indonesia (three), Brunei (two) and Singapore (one). Indonesia quarrels with Malaysia over the status of the Sipadan and Ligitan Islands in the Sulawesi Sea close to the border between Sabah and Kalimantan. Indonesia is also involved in a dispute with Vietnam concerning overlapping continental shelf areas in the South China Sea north of the Indonesian Natuna Islands (Dosch 1997a: 133–45). But the ASEAN dialogue mechanisms worked effectively enough to produce peaceful conflict management. Perhaps the most valuable achievement of the ASEAN security model is that it has successfully managed to keep residual conflicts between the members (especially territorial disputes) from leading to armed confrontation in the ASEAN since the end of *Konfrontasi*.
- Another important dialogue level refers to matters of external security. Although ASEAN was never and will not be in the foreseeable future a security alliance like NATO, it comes close to Karl W. Deutsch's idea of a soft, but working security community (because

no ASEAN member would seriously consider the use of military force as a means of problem solving in intermember relations). Peaceful conflict management in the international field is not an easy undertaking, maintained via a gamut of dialogues and confidence-building measures (often on a bilateral or trilateral basis), and a corresponding security philosophy far beyond the ZOPFAN concept. Brokerage, undertaken both within the group and among the trickier regional and global shareholders of power and expansionist spirits, is the gist of this security philosophy. ASEAN has always demonstrated its will to find regional solutions for regional problems. Three examples are: (1) ASEAN contributed to the political solution of the Cambodian conflict as one, if not the most important major player in the peace negotiation process (unfortunately, this peace process seems to have suffered a setback); (2) At the 25th Meeting of the ASEAN Foreign Ministers in Manila 1992, ASEAN adopted the 'Declaration on the South China Sea', regarded as a first step towards a peaceful settlement of this dispute; and (3). At the ASEAN Bangkok Summit in December 1995, a treaty was signed which bans the development, acquisition, use, testing and stationing of nuclear arms in Southeast Asia. It is a notable achievement that ASEAN got not only its then seven members but also the remaining states of Southeast Asia (Cambodia, Laos and Myanmar) to sign the 'South-East Asia Nuclear Weapon-Free Zone Treaty'.

- An outstanding dialogue achievement is ASEAN's formal dialogue programme with important external powers. Like no other group of countries in the 'Third World' (not even the Latin American Rio Group), ASEAN has managed to gain international attention through its well-established dialogue sessions conducted at high levels. This type of dialogue produced three main results in favour of ASEAN: the association is regarded as an equal and important actor in the international field, ASEAN's opportunities to enter into regular exchange of views with leading world powers, and the capacity of the group to play a respected role in international fora like the Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation (APEC) or even to parent new institutions like the ASEAN Regional Forum (ARF). For example, the fact that ASEAN was able to convince China to participate in the ARF to discuss security issues of international concern must be considered one of ASEAN's most valuable achievements in foreign diplomacy.
- ASEAN conducts a dialogue of mutual reinforcement in matters of development and stability. Identical or comparable economic and developmental philosophies, a comparable weight given to the positive capacity of political stability and predictability produced a synergistic effect of reinforcement of developmental behaviour and ideas, concepts of government, and political and economic performance. The formula of a dialectic relationship between national and regional

resilience serves as an umbrella concept in this respect. As Michael Leifer (1996: 14) explains: national resilience 'would be achieved by creating a stable domestic political order that would encourage fruitful economic development. In turn, this economic growth would reinforce the underlying political order. The ideal aggregate expression of "national resilience" in Southeast Asia as a whole was seen as "regional resilience" – a condition in which regional cooperation would reduce external threat and prevent internal political disorder from spreading across common borders.'

- Dialogue was one of the mechanisms in the field of economic affairs. Skipping the first twenty-five years of ASEAN, economic breakthroughs were definitely far less successful than political achievements, with one exception. There emerged a growing personal familiarity between business and administrative elites and amongst certain ranks within the business groups themselves, which laid the foundation for an ASEAN elite cohesiveness that was the basis for more recent and keener undertakings like CEPT or AFTA. The future possibilities of the growth triangles belong to this level of economic–political dialogues, at least within the ASEAN group itself.

If we combine these factors and neglect for a moment certain difficulties and shortcomings (which will be presented in the next section), it was this bunch of dialogues which substantially contributed to Kernial Sandhu's sense of a promotion of stability and security and to the image of ASEAN as a respected figure on the chessboard of international relations. ASEAN's manifestation of a living and thriving regionalism is matched only by the European Union, surpassing even the remarkably successful MERCOSUR. Peace, economic development, international acceptance and a constructive international role were achieved as well as a broker position within East Asia and the Asia-Pacific. Should and could the ASEAN success story continue along its traditional lines and experiences into the next century?

ASEAN at a turning point

The success of the 'ASEAN way' or 'ASEAN model' is best summarized by Oxford Professor Robert O'Neill:

> Look at the internal weakness of the Southeast Asian region in the 1950s and 1960s, and compare them with the present situation. No region is beyond working out a more secure future for itself. The resources required to form an effective regional linkage are more matters of political will, diplomacy, planning and common sense than of money and armed forces.
>
> (O'Neill 1995: 147)

However, as mentioned above, the international events and developments which have completely changed the international constellation since the end of the 1980s and the beginning of the 1990s are posing major challenges for ASEAN and increasingly forcing the Association to adopt new patterns of strategy.

The bipolar world at the time of the Bangkok Declaration and its aftermath was not friendly but nearly always predictable. The leaders of ASEAN were prudent enough to contribute to a regional power equilibrium *sui generis*. *ASEAN im Kräftefeld der Großmächte* ('ASEAN in the Field of Forces of the Big Powers') was, at end of the 1980s, the title of an outstanding book by Philippine scholar Julius Caesar Parreñas (1989). The author convincingly pointed out that the ASEAN group was not just a white spot within the parallelogram of powers like the US, China, Japan, Vietnam, and others, but was able to palpably contribute to this regional power equilibrium, the fundamental precondition for its resilience-philosophy. In retrospect, it can be concluded that the clear structure of bipolarity and East–West confrontation served ASEAN well. It kept the United States engaged in the region as a guarantor of a secure geopolitical environment. And it contained the power projection interests of all three major actors: the US, the Soviet Union and China. The world of today no longer reveals these former predictabilities and no longer allows us 'to make haste slowly', as Lee Kuan Yew once described ASEAN's prudent approach to problem solving. Uncertainties concerning the new regional political–security architecture in the wake of the Cold War include:

- shifting power relativities between the major states;
- the gradual rise of a multi-polar security environment with the major Asian powers playing a larger role;
- significant increases in military capabilities and local defence industries;
- the possibility of ethnic and national tensions, economic rivalry, disappointing aspirations for prosperity, and religious or racial conflict.

It would be misleading, however, to focus only on a changed political–security environment to which ASEAN must adopt. Simultaneous economic challenges are obvious. In 1997, 'the Southeast Asian states were ... painfully reminded of structural shortcomings concerning the rapid development of their Association for peace and welfare. ... The welfare-securing system of a fiscal and monetary policy oriented to the US Dollar began to crumble' (FAZ/OAV 1997: 3). ASEAN leaders cannot rely any more on the fact that they have created a peaceful and stable regional situation which in turn has contributed to a conductive climate for ASEAN countries to pursue their national economic development. Stability, reliability and predictability have made the region one of the most attractive investment areas in the world for the past two decades. However, the 1997

currency crisis demonstrates that the promotion of national and regional resilience and trust-building consultation processes are no longer sufficient to match present and future global developments, even if traditional strategies proved to be successful for many years.

The basic question is to what degree past experiences, past types of style, past performance and also past patterns of organization, past interpretations of its own possibilities and its role in the world should be kept and maintained and where innovation, perhaps drastic innovation, is required and perhaps overdue. This question about the future of ASEAN contains four subelements:

1 remarks on the proper organization of ASEAN;
2 comments upon the timing and proper memberships of expanding ASEAN;
3 an indispensable new equilibrium between an active and reactive role;
4 a final contra-factual statement about what would happen if ASEAN continues with its existing traditional structures and patterns of behaviour.

A possible restructuring of ASEAN

Re-engineering ASEAN, to use the title of a recent article by M. C. Abad (1996) in the journal *Contemporary Southeast Asia* will be the task ahead. A discussion about institutional reform is relatively familiar in ASEAN circles, whose 'Group of Fourteen' dedicated a substantial amount of time and energy to this problem (Sopiee *et al.* 1987; Group of Fourteen 1987) as did a number of distinguished ASEAN scholars under titles such as 'ASEAN at the Crossroads', 'Whither ASEAN', and 'Quo vadis ASEAN?' Whatever new structures will be introduced, it is necessary to further strengthen the secretariat working with more and more responsible central authorities. A club of senior statesmen with rotating responsibilities will no longer suffice, neither will rotating groups of senior officials. It seems to be a paradox: The ASEAN organization is too simple and at the same time too complex with its hundreds of desks, committees, sub- and sub-subcommittees, regular and irregular meetings, conferences etc. Within the existing structures, three problems cannot be resolved properly:

1 Who coordinates a mushrooming set of formal and informal organizations, structures and activities, and gives coherence to its manifold suggestions, proposals and decisions? (Neither the summits nor the AMMs are able to fulfil this task at least on day-to-day matters.)
2 Who translates ministerial and committee (and of course presidential) decisions into national policies?
3 Who plays on the world stage the role of a representative and responsible speaker of the group?

ASEAN is facing the same problem that Europe is trying to solve: widening versus deepening. ASEAN decided to widen first, leaving aside the results of the important Singapore Summit in 1992. It would be an illusion to think that deepening currently can be avoided:

> ASEAN's senior members were fortunate to have had three decades over which to develop camaraderie and familiarity. They will not have the same luxury in their relationship with the newcomers. The integration of Vietnam, Cambodia, Laos, and Myanmar must be a clear and deliberate process.
>
> (*Asiaweek*, 27 June 1997: 16)

We would like to add, . . . a clear and deliberate process held together by a higher and definitely improved degree of organizational capacity, coherence and responsibility.

The question of re-engineering comes up again in the context of the current objective of the Association. The messages of recent ministerial and senior officials meetings were clear and unequivocal, 'greater economic integration' as stated by the ASEAN finance ministers in March 1997 (*ASEAN Update*, Vol. 1/1997: 3). In this respect, ASEAN actors have changed their approach and attitude. For more than two decades, the term integration was constantly avoided and remained taboo within ASEAN, at least at the higher political levels. It was stressed that ASEAN never intended to emulate economic integration, a concept regarded as being too close to European experiences and therefore alien to Southeast Asian circumstances. It is likewise interesting to observe that ministers now dedicate quite an amount of their time to the problem of finding an adequate mechanism for formal conflict resolution beyond the traditional dialogue and persuasion concepts of *musyawarah* (discussion) and *mufakat* (consensus) (Mols 1996: 172ff.).[1] Traditional ASEAN negotiation styles, as analysed over a decade ago by Pushpa Thambipillai and J. Saravannamuttu (1985), are losing attraction within the Association or begin to be dysfunctional. There exists on one hand the temptation to refer to traditional codes of conduct ASEAN style (Hoang Ahn Tuan 1996). But on the other hand, shrewd analysts leave no doubt that 'a bigger organization needs focused efforts at integration' (*Asiaweek*, 27 June 1997: 14). The current ASEAN reflections on problem solving are still far away from a court or tribunal with binding decisions for its members. However, in an intermediate future, another issue will appear on the horizon. If integration (and not just only economic integration) is considered seriously, the question of some transfers of national sovereignty will be raised.

Enter Cambodia, Laos, Myanmar and Vietnam. A fresh overview on 'Regionalism in Southeast Asia' has been written by Professor James Clad of Georgetown University in the 1997 issue of *Southeast Asian Affairs*

(Clad 1997: 3–12). Reference to domestic political transition problems is one of his points, which is not only sensitive with regards to the political stability of the states of the ASEAN group. The other point is the danger of regional overreach. Anybody who has read Kennedy's book, *The Rise and Fall of the Great Powers* (Kennedy 1989), or Paul Sanders's *Losing an Empire, Finding a Role* (Sanders 1990) will immediately know what overreach or overstretch mean: an international appearance, capacity and performance beyond available resources. The fate of the Roman Empire, the German Imperium Romanum in the Middle Ages, the British Empire until the famous Suez Crisis, and probably the American Empire with its philosophy of an international *pax americana* are cases in point. ASEAN, the ASEAN of six, nine or even of ten, is not a hegemonic enterprise. And yet, does the present enlargement, begun with Vietnam in 1995, not extend its political and organizational capacities? And its simple capacities of integration? Additionally, if new countries are admitted or coopted into a proven association, the question should be permitted whether these countries appear ready or not. What was and is the motivating objective of the group for an enlargement which transcends a trustworthy and experienced way of politically living together?

The answer is suggested by Abad: 'ASEAN is now in the process of transition from a multilateral framework for the pursuit of unilateral national interests to an intergovernmental organization promoting regional interests vis-à-vis the rest of the world' (Abad 1996: 250). What does this 'rest of the world' mean?

Politically, 'ASEAN countries recognize that their security, both at home and in the region, depends on a pluralism of power' (Wanandi 1996: 127). This again bears different implications. There is a certain danger of the emergence of a security triangle, consisting of the USA, China and Japan. If ASEAN wants to remain a significant actor, it has to be attractive to make such a triangle less exclusive, hence the necessity for an enlargement. The same logic holds true with regards to an imaginable Asian power vacuum, eventually filled on the large East–South Asian land bridge by China and India. (Djiwandono 1996: 339). Here again, a danger of a potential loss of international autonomy can, according to quite a few ASEAN statesmen, be avoided best by a demonstration of the Association's importance and in terms of population, countries involved, square kilometres, current and future GDP. If it makes sense to keep both the USA and China in the region as active partners for ASEAN, there is a certain logic for any argument that an enlarged group shows in the long run a heightened attraction even for the big powers, particularly if the latter have to recognize that subregional order in Southeast Asia cannot function without a working and thriving ASEAN. ASEAN therefore counts upon mutual international interests to improve its status as a major international player. Jusuf Wanandi is correct when saying:

> ASEAN needs both great powers [China and the US] to be present. ... ASEAN needs the US presence to maintain a balance between the great powers in the region, and ASEAN would like to have China incorporated in the region in cooperative security arrangements.
>
> (Wanandi 1996: 127)

His presupposition seems realistic that this is also in the interest of Washington and Beijing. To achieve the goal of cooperative security arrangements in the region, ASEAN can base new strategies on its well-established diplomacy mechanisms. Here, the connection between past experiences and behaviours and today's challenges and strategic necessities is evident. ASEAN's policy of establishing a stable and secure geostrategic environment through cooperation and dialogue rather than through political or even military confrontation is now bearing fruit. For example, thanks to ASEAN's initiative of finding a peaceful solution concerning the Spratly Islands dispute, Chinese Foreign Minister Qian Qichen hinted in July 1995 that

> China would be willing to use international law and the 1982 Convention of the Law of the Sea as a basis for negotiating the issue [of the South China Sea dispute] and that it would discuss the issue with all seven members of ASEAN.
>
> (Valencia and Van Dyke 1996: 227)

There remains, however, the question whether ASEAN leaders are not too tempted to a certain yielding to the changing international situation. Flexibility is definitely required and in its wake innovation, and perhaps enlargement. Proper timing is another requirement. Gorbachev said, 'Who comes late will be punished by life', but the reverse can be equally problematic. Who appears too early will suffer from headaches, to put it very mildly. That ASEAN took on more than it could handle was revealed by Cambodia, its treatment and corresponding international comments (compare, for example, *The Economist*, 19–25 July 1997: 53, and various entries of the *Far Eastern Economic Review* of Summer 1997). And also the incorporation of Myanmar against the misgivings of the US and Europe, on one hand an issue of the Association's international autonomy, likewise endangers its relations with two substantially important and traditionally friendly dialogue partners in the West. The consequence may also include the incipient ASEM process which follows ASEAN's philosophy more than Europe's.

That right timing is a topical problem within ASEAN can be observed on various occasions. The current *trois vitesse*-philosophy of the ASEAN Free Trade Area (AFTA) is one example. If ASEAN leaders turn nervous *vis-à-vis* a changing international and regional environment, they run the

risk of precipitating isolating decisions. Perhaps Dr Mahathir's proposal of December 1990 to form an exclusive East Asia Economic Group (EAEG) and the following various interpretations of the idea fall into this category, as does the Indonesia–Australia agreement or the new foundation of an Asian 'Group of Six' (which includes Singapore) as a counterweight to the 'Group of Seven' (*Südostasien aktuell*, März 1997: 107). Single governments like Malaysia, Thailand, Singapore or Indonesia pursue policies of solo attempts to assure their nation-states' positions and behaviours in relations with their neighbouring countries, beyond any officially declared spirit of ASEAN. They worry about a changing world in which the traditional ASEAN group is not sufficient to assure national identities and autonomies. Even the ASEAN Regional Forum (ARF), although an achievement (but not the original idea) of ASEAN, is not basically the fruit of the dialogue experiences of ASEAN, but primarily the result of strategic thinking. ASEAN viewed the ARF as a way of keeping the United States engaged in the region and rising powers such as China and Japan restrained, and as a means to reassure the smaller ASEAN states (Khong Yuen Foong 1996: 60). One can interpret the PMC–ARF–CSCAP process as a basic network which has the 'potential to serve as the nucleus of an evolving security order in the Asia-Pacific' (Dosch 1997b: 13). But one must admit that the extreme care to avoid any stronger and binding multilateralism in the field of security (Djiwandono 1996: 348) reflects an intrinsic caution of the main ASEAN players to avoid relations that touch upon questions of national sovereignty. Does the development of the international security panorama allow such caution in the long run? Pundits like Parreñas even envisage a future political union (Parreñas 1997), but at least for the time being, the personalities responsible for ASEAN prefer a state-centred dialogue coordination as a proven mechanism for the functioning of the Association (Ganesan 1995). But do the growing pressures of strong external influences or even 'external federators' justify the resort to past experiences?

Externally induced considerations provide, for example, an additional clear motive for the acceleration of economic cooperation, represented by CEPT and AFTA measures and AFTA timing (and of the enlargement of the ASEAN membership). The general impression is that the agreed programmes work, particularly if we compare the new economic cooperation process with its multi-layered predecessor before 1993. The main reason is expected cross-country spillover effects 'to be rising in the future with increasing factor flows as in capital and labour, and trade flows, harmonization or convergence of investment policies and growth strategies' (To and Low 1996: 69).

A possibly successful implementation of AFTA as well as immense flows of trade and investment into and within the ASEAN group cannot deny that ASEAN governments and the private sector both belong to a larger set of economic groupings, namely PECC, PBEC and APEC. APEC,

however, has been qualified as an experiment. There remains an existing preoccupation that 'ASEAN ... may be eclipsed by bigger forces. One of them is APEC' (Vatikiotis 1995: 60). This fear might be justified. AFTA's free-trade concept coincides with the basic APEC philosophy. Furthermore, the danger (from an ASEAN point of view) that basic initiatives are taken by the larger group appears imminent. If ASEAN wants to maintain its economic coherence or identity *vis-à-vis* APEC and other trans-Pacific economic groupings, it must pursue a common market. Here again, the current paradox reappears. On the one hand, external pressures to adopt oneself to international global economic necessities are as obvious as its trade vulnerability (Zhang 1996) and its dependent small R&D activities (perhaps with the exception of Singapore). On the other hand and despite the success of the APEC Bogor Conference, the majority of ASEAN leaders prefer a discussion forum and consultative scheme, repeating once more ASEAN's basic philosophy of non-binding dialogues. No wonder that APEC membership is seen primarily as a means to improve the reputation of the Association, despite that 'in the midst of all these uncertainties regarding regional economic cooperation, individual member countries in ASEAN have undertaken unilateral initiatives that go beyond the confines of ASEAN in Southeast Asia' (Ganesan 1995: 222). The international growth triangles and sub-regional projects are examples.

ASEAN is at a crossroads to decide what it really wants, which procedural and institutional tools should be developed and introduced, and how it places itself in 'Asia-Pacific as a dominant political system ... with its economic dynamism' (Alagappa 1997: 29).

Some final remarks

If we combine some key factors identified in this short article (ASEAN's future identity, new international framework conditions including China as today's central 'external federator', the tendency towards economic integration, degrees of a future transfer of sovereignty, regional over-reach, proper or hasty timing, ASEAN's arrangement in larger groups), there is no alternative but to discuss these things in the light of past ASEAN experiences and international learning on regional cooperation and integration.

Foreign Minister Jayakumar of Singapore was right when he urged 'ASEAN to learn to move at the pace of the rapidly changing world' and therefore to become a 'rapid reaction organization' (quoted in Abad 1996: 250). This does not imply that ASEAN should give up its positive experience of the thirty years of successful enterprise, including the rules, norms and practices that helped the group as an important factor in international relations. However, if ASEAN is to develop into a major player, it must consider experiences of other regions and regionalisms.

We are not arguing for Europe as a unique paradigm for regional integration or for international soft power radiating from Brussels and the surrounding European capitals. Europeans have their own problems concerning widening and deepening and over-bureaucratization, as well as different types of federalism, subsidiarity and rivalry between some key countries.

In the ASEAN–EU Ministers' Joint Declaration of 14 February 1997 in Singapore, the ministers mentioned 'the unique knowledge the EU had acquired in completing the Single Market and ASEAN had acquired in implementing AFTA . . .' (*Südostasien aktuell*, März 1997: 156). There is also unique knowledge in the Caribbean in promoting community identification, in Latin America's practice of *concertacion* (Tomassini 1990), and in the MERCOSUR countries about the participatory roles of private initiative in integration.

Who should mediate such experiences if not we, academics, working in universities and think tanks? 'Thirty years of ASEAN' is the basis for recognizing that past experience, the projected experience of political vision and the analytic experience of contemporary regionalism should come together!

Acknowledgements

The authors wish to thank Michael Stankiewicz for his valuable comments on an earlier draft of this article. This and the following articles are based on papers presented at the international conference '30 Years of ASEAN' at the Johannes Gutenberg-University of Mainz, 10–12 July 1997, sponsored by the Fritz-Thyssen-Foundation.

Note

1 More specifically, the idea of introducing a Dispute Settlement Mechanism (DSM) as it was agreed upon during the 28th ASEAN Economic Ministers Meeting in Jakarta on 12 September 1996 (*ASEAN Update*, Vol. 4/1996: 2). In general the actual and controversial ASEAN concept of 'constructive intervention' in Cambodia (see *Asiaweek*, 22 August 1997: 12) provides a good example of a new diplomatic style which no longer gives first priority to harmony and consensus.

References

Abad, M. C. Jr (1996) 'Re-engineering ASEAN', *Contemporary Southeast Asia* 18(3): 237–53.

Alagappa, Muthia (1997) 'Systemic change, security, and governance in the Asia-Pacific', in Chan Heng Chee (ed.) *The New Asia-Pacific Order*, Singapore: Institute of Southeast Asian Studies (ISEAS), pp. 29–81.

Anwar, Dewi Fortuna (1994) *Indonesia in Asia. Foreign Policy and Regionalism*, Singapore.

Clad, James (1997) 'Regionalism in Southeast Asia. A bridge too far?', *Southeast Asian Affairs 1997*, Singapore: Institute of Southeast Asian Studies (ISEAS), pp. 3–12.

Djiwandono, J. Soedjati (1996) 'Defence cooperation between member-states of ASEAN', *The Indonesian Quarterly* XXIV(4): 339–51.

Dosch, Jörn (1997a) *Die ASEAN: Bilanz eines Erfolges*, Hamburg: Abera.

—— (1997b) *PMC, ARF and CSCAP: Foundations for a Security Architecture in the Asia-Pacific?*, Canberra: Strategic & Defence Centre, Australian National University (Working Paper No. 307).

FAZ/OAV (Frankfurter Allgemeine Zeitung GmbH Informationsdienste/ Ostasiatischer Verein e.V.) (1997) *Länderanalyse Singapur/ASEAN*, Juli.

Ganesan, N. (1995) 'Rethinking ASEAN as a security community in Southeast Asia', *Asian Affairs* 21(4): 210–26.

Group of Fourteen (1987) *ASEAN: The Way Forward. The Report of the Group of Fourteen on ASEAN Economic Cooperation and Integration*, Kuala Lumpur: Institute of Strategic and International Studies (ISIS), Malaysia.

Hoang Ahn Tuan (1996) 'ASEAN dispute management: implications for Vietnam and an expanded ASEAN', *Contemporary Southeast Asia* 18(1): 61–80.

Jensen, Kenneth M. (ed.) (1990) *A Look at 'The End of History'*, Washington, DC: United States Institute of Peace.

Jorgensen-Dahl, Arnfinn (1982) *Regional Organization and Order in South-East Asia*, London: Macmillan.

Kennedy, Paul (1989) *The Rise and the Fall of the Great Powers. Economic Change and Military Conflict from 1500 to 2000*, New York: Vintage Books.

Khong Yuen Foong (1996) 'Predicting the future of the ASEAN Regional Forum', in Derek Da Cunha (ed.) *The Evolving Pacific Power Structure*, Singapore: Institute of Southeast Asian Studies (ISEAS), pp. 55–62.

Leifer, Michael (1996) *The ASEAN Regional Forum: Extending ASEAN's Model of Regional Security*, Oxford: Oxford University Press for the International Institute of Security Studies (Adelphi Paper 302).

Mahani Zainal Abidin (1997) 'ASEAN economies. Continuing competitiveness through industrial restructuring', *Southeast Asian Affairs 1997*, Singapore: Institute of Southeast Asian Studies (ISEAS), pp. 15–32.

Mols, Manfred (1993) 'The integration agenda: a framework for comparison', in Peter H. Smith (ed.) *The Challenge of Integration, Europe and the Americas*, New Brunswick, NJ, and London: Transaction Publishers, pp. 51–75.

—— (1996) *Integration und Kooperation in zwei Kontinenten. Das Streben nach Einheit in Lateinamerika und in Südostasien*, Stuttgart: Steiner.

O'Neill, Robert (1995) 'A world without superpowers?', in Corall Bell (ed.) *Nation, Region and Context. Studies in Peace and War in Honour of Professor T. B. Millar*, Canberra: Australian National University (Canberra Papers on Strategy and Defence No. 112), pp. 133–48.

Parreñas, Julius Caesar (1989) *ASEAN im Kräftefeld der Großmächte*, Frankfurt am Main, Bern, New York and Paris: Peter Lang.

—— (1997) 'The future of ASEAN', in Chan Heng Chee (ed.) *The New Asia-Pacific Order*, Singapore: Institute of Southeast Asian Studies (ISEAS), pp. 186–219.

Sanders, David (1990) *Losing an Empire, Finding a Role. British Foreign Policy since 1945*, Basingstoke: Macmillan.

Sandhu, Kernial S. (ed.) (1992) *The ASEAN Reader*, Singapore: Institute of Southeast Asian Studies (ISEAS).

Sopiee, Noordin, Chew Lay See and Lim Siang Jin (eds) (1987) *ASEAN at the Crossroads. Obstacles & Opportunities in Economic Co-operation*, Kuala Lumpur: Institute of Strategic and International Studies (ISIS), Malaysia.

Thambipillai, Pushpa and Saravannamuttu, J. (1985) *ASEAN Negotiations. Two Insights,* Singapore: Institute of Southeast Asian Studies (ISEAS).

To Mun Heng and Low, Linda (1996) 'Linkages among the ASEAN economies. A multi-country model analysis', *ASEAN Economic Bulletin* 13(1): 52–73.

Tomassini, Luciano (ed.) (1990) *Nuevas formas de concertación regional en América Latina: El Sistema International y America Latina,* Buenos Aires: Grupo Editor Latinoamericano.

Valencia, Mark and Van Dyke, Jon M. (1996) 'Comprehensive solutions to the South China Sea disputes: some options', in Sam Bateman and Stephen Bates (eds) *The Seas Unite: Maritime Cooperation in the Asia-Pacific Region,* Canberra: Australian National University, pp. 223–62 (Canberra Papers on Strategy and Defence No. 118).

Vatikiotis, Michael (1995) 'Running to stay in front', *Far Eastern Economic Review* 14 (September): 60–1.

Wanandi, Jusuf (1996) 'ASEAN's China strategy: towards deeper engagement', *Survival* 38(3): 117–27.

Zhang, Zhaoyong (1996) 'AFTA and APEC, with policy implications for Vietnam's trade and FDI', *Development Policy Review* 14: 273–97.